Outside the administration, even Nixon came to Nehru's defense, welcoming the prime minister's "inspiring leadership." In a tirade about neutral countries, he noted that "to his credit" Nehru was not one of the nonaligned leaders who tried to blackmail the US into providing aid by threatening to go communist. He pointed out that the Indian prime minister had been the only leader at Belgrade who had given the Soviet Union more than a "gentle slap on the wrist" for resuming atomic tests.[185]

More importantly from India's perspective, the administration moved forward on supporting India on both the defense and development fronts. Secretary of State Dean Rusk went beyond the traditional American position on the Sino-Indian border, stating at a press conference in December, "We, of course, support the Indian view with respect to their northern borders. Those borders have been well established in law, if not, in every locality, demarcated exactly on the ground. But the McMahon Line generally is something that the rest of the world has accepted."[186] Furthermore, just a month after Kennedy had ordered a hold on aid to India because of its military takeover of Goa (then in Portuguese hands), he approved its release in early 1962.[187] That Indian use of force had brought US condemnation at the UN, despite Rusk's instructions to limit public censure because of the consequences for the US-India partnership.[188] The lack of criticism of Portuguese colonialism upset India. One official wryly commented that if Delhi had instead "launched an offensive against the Chinese to regain our territory we would of course be applauded as heroes."[189] Kennedy's lifting of the aid hold, however, allowed both countries to move on.

In summer 1962, however, the aid program seemed under threat in in the Senate. Senator Stuart Symington (D-MO) led an effort to cut the proposed aid package for India by 25 percent, citing the lack of an India-Pakistan settlement, Krishna Menon's statements the previous fall, and India's ties with the Soviet Union. Reports of a potential Indian defense deal with the Soviet Union only increased the size of the target on India's back in Congress. Kennedy personally intervened to save the Indian aid program. The administration managed to limit the cut; Congress approved $400 million of the $450 million requested for India for FY1963.[190] The signs, however, did not bode well for the future. It was the first time in years that